

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Ethics and Human Interface - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Ethics and Human Interface

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Where Ethics Enters Everyday Public Life

2 Four Ways to Ask an Ethical Question

3 Ethics, Morality, Law, and Propriety

4 The Human Interface: Power Meets Citizen Need

5 Why Values Need Institutions

6 How Systems Produce or Prevent Corruption

7 Coercive and Collusive Corruption: Do Not Confuse Them

8 Citizen Power, Transparency, and Ethical Governance

9 Constitutional Morality and National Power

10 Writing a Balanced GS-IV Ethics Answer

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Generation: learner-v2:g2 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A district team surveys customary views on accepting festival gifts, then asks whether the practice is defensible for procurement officers. Which part is moral description and which is ethical evaluation? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.
- B. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread.
- C. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- D. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Ethics and morality** is the controlling principle. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A senior says, 'Everyone in this office gives priority to relatives, so it is right.' Identify why a shared practice does not by itself settle an ethical question. Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- B. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.
- C. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers.
- D. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Ethics and morality** is the controlling principle. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A state training institute reports that many field staff see small facilitation payments as normal. Is its report descriptive ethics, a normative defence, or both? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.
- B. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.
- C. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread.
- D. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.

Answer: C

Explanation: Descriptive inquiry is the controlling principle. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A municipal survey finds that residents tolerate queue-jumping for elderly relatives. What additional inquiry is needed before an officer can adopt the practice as policy? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.
- B. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- C. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers.
- D. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread.

Answer: D

Explanation: Descriptive inquiry is the controlling principle. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

A hospital superintendent must decide whether to publish a waiting list despite staff discomfort. Which inquiry tests the duty of fairness rather than merely measuring staff opinion? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- B. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers.
- C. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.
- D. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.

Answer: A

Explanation: Normative inquiry is the controlling principle. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A panchayat notes that a majority supports excluding migrants from a water queue. Which ethical approach asks whether the majority preference is justifiable? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.
- B. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- C. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.
- D. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread.

Answer: B

Explanation: Normative inquiry is the controlling principle. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

Two trainees debate whether the word 'integrity' can ever have a truth value, without discussing a pending service decision. Which level of ethical inquiry is their debate conducting? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread.
- B. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- C. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers.
- D. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.

Answer: C

Explanation: Meta-ethics is the controlling principle. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

An answer to a flood-relief dilemma spends its entire space on whether moral judgments are objective. Why does that miss the principal applied task? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- B. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.
- C. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.
- D. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers.

Answer: D

Explanation: Meta-ethics is the controlling principle. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A district magistrate applies fairness, harm prevention, and accountability to an AI-assisted beneficiary list. Why is this applied ethics rather than meta-ethics? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.
- B. Ethics is the systematic and reasoned examination of standards of right conduct, whereas morality denotes the beliefs and practices actually held by persons or communities; they overlap in ordinary usage but should be distinguished when an ethical claim is being critically assessed.
- C. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread.
- D. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Applied ethics** is the controlling principle. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A doctor explains that confidentiality is important, then decides whether to share a notifiable disease report with the health authority. What makes this an applied ethical decision? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Descriptive ethics records what individuals or groups in fact believe, approve, or do; it neither establishes what they ought to do nor excuses a practice merely because it is widespread.
- B. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory.
- C. Normative ethics asks what ought to be done and justifies the answer through standards such as duty, consequences, justice, or virtue; it cannot be reduced to a report of prevailing attitudes.
- D. Meta-ethics examines the meaning, status, and possible truth of moral language, for example whether 'wrong' states an objective fact or expresses an attitude; it is conceptually useful but usually subordinate to normative and applied reasoning in GS-IV answers.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Applied ethics** is the controlling principle. Applied ethics brings normative standards to a definite domain, such as public administration, medicine, business, environmental regulation, or artificial intelligence, by testing a concrete decision rather than merely naming a theory. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A licensing officer accepts a lavish dinner from a bidder before any formal decision. No payment is proved and no rule is visibly breached. Which ethical test most clearly identifies the public-confidence problem? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- B. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.
- C. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.
- D. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Legality, morality, propriety** is the controlling principle. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A municipal councillor lawfully uses official social media to praise a relative's firm during a tender period. Why is legality alone an incomplete ethical defence? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.
- B. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.
- C. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- D. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Legality, morality, propriety** is the controlling principle. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A collector arranges a private interview with one of several land-acquisition bidders outside office hours, while retaining the formal record required by law. What concern arises even if the meeting is not expressly prohibited? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- B. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.
- C. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.
- D. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.

Answer: A

Explanation: Spirit and letter is the controlling principle. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

An officer awards a contract after following every formality but suppresses a known conflict that did not trigger a mandatory disclosure rule. Which distinction exposes the ethical defect? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.
- B. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- C. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.
- D. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.

Answer: B

Explanation: Spirit and letter is the controlling principle. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A widow seeking a pension must repeatedly meet a clerk who can delay verification. Why is this more than a technical service-delivery problem? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.
- B. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- C. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.
- D. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Human interface** is the controlling principle. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A fully automated utility payment system gives identical receipts and appeal routes to every user. Which part of the human-interface ethical risk has it reduced? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- B. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.
- C. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.
- D. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Human interface** is the controlling principle. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A welfare officer sincerely wants to help a neighbour but bypasses the published eligibility list. Which professional dimensions besides benevolent intention must be tested? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.
- B. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.
- C. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- D. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.

Answer: A

Explanation: Professional decision-making is the controlling principle. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A public hospital adopts a triage rule that is transparent and reviewable but produces hard individual outcomes. Why is accountability relevant alongside compassion? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical public conduct requires attention to the spirit as well as the letter of rules, because narrowly legal conduct may create a reasonable appearance of bias, private favour, or misuse of entrusted position.
- B. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision.
- C. The human interface is the point at which an official's public duty encounters a citizen's need and possible private interest; ethical quality is tested most sharply where discretion, vulnerability, delay, and unequal power converge.
- D. Legality tests conformity with enacted law, morality tests conformity with a standard of right conduct, and propriety tests what is appropriate to an office and occasion; an action can satisfy the letter of law yet fail morality or public propriety.

Answer: B

Explanation: Professional decision-making is the controlling principle. Responsible professional decision-making combines reasons, relevant facts, duty to affected persons, foreseeable consequences, fairness, and accountability; personal good intention alone cannot cure a biased procedure or an unreviewable decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A department conducts an integrity pledge every Monday but has no audit trail for approvals. Why may its values programme fail under procurement pressure? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.
- B. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- C. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.
- D. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.

Answer: C

Explanation: Values and institutions is the controlling principle. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

Another department installs surveillance and harsh penalties but never trains staff to recognise conflicts of interest. What limitation does the values-institutions framework reveal? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- B. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.
- C. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value.
- D. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.

Answer: D

Explanation: Values and institutions is the controlling principle. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

After bribery complaints, a state orders only motivational lectures for revenue staff while leaving approvals discretionary and unrecorded. Which causal explanation is being overextended? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- B. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value.
- C. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.
- D. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.

Answer: A

Explanation: Decline-of-values view is the controlling principle. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A trainee says all corruption proves officials are personally immoral. How would the structural account qualify, rather than wholly deny, that claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.
- B. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- C. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.
- D. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.

Answer: B

Explanation: Decline-of-values view is the controlling principle. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A vigilance drive arrests several brokers but retains the same manual, opaque permit process that created demand for brokers. What does the deviant-minority view miss? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- B. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value.
- C. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.
- D. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.

Answer: C

Explanation: Deviant-minority view is the controlling principle. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A department says one suspended officer has solved its ethical problem. Which institutional question should an auditor ask next? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value.
- B. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.
- C. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.
- D. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.

Answer: D

Explanation: Deviant-minority view is the controlling principle. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A tribal applicant cannot read the online land-record status and relies on an intermediary connected to the office. Which structural ethical condition is most relevant before blaming the applicant for paying a fee? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value.
- B. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.
- C. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- D. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.

Answer: A

Explanation: Asymmetry of power is the controlling principle. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A service centre displays timelines, fees, reasons for rejection, and an independent appeal channel. How does this change the official-citizen power relationship? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- B. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value.
- C. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.
- D. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.

Answer: B

Explanation: Asymmetry of power is the controlling principle. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

A village water repair waits for four remote approvals, each without a public timeline. Which mechanism links this design to the ethical quality of service? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Asymmetry of power weakens the citizen's ability to demand ethical conduct because the official controls information, time, access, or certification; transparency, voice, and review mechanisms therefore have ethical as well as administrative value.
- B. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.
- C. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.
- D. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.

Answer: C

Explanation: Centralisation and accountability is the controlling principle. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A gram panchayat receives fund-control power but keeps no public works register. Why is decentralisation not automatically an integrity guarantee? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Values orient conduct, but durable integrity also needs institutional containers: clear procedures, transparency, competent supervision, sanctions, and appeal routes. Neither moral exhortation alone nor punishment alone adequately explains or corrects ethical failure.
- B. The decline-of-values explanation locates corruption primarily in weakened character and therefore stresses moral renewal; it identifies a real concern but is incomplete when it overlooks discretion, opacity, monopoly, and incentives created by institutions.
- C. The deviant-minority explanation treats corruption as the work of a small self-interested group and emphasises detection and punishment; deterrence is necessary, but this view is incomplete where routine systems reward opaque discretion or make citizens dependent.
- D. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies.

Answer: D

Explanation: Centralisation and accountability is the controlling principle. Over-centralisation can widen the distance between authority and accountability by placing many functionaries between the citizen and the decision-maker; decentralisation helps only when local capacity, transparency, and audit prevent smaller discretionary monopolies. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A clerk refuses to release a widow's sanctioned pension unless she pays a 'file movement' charge. Is the widow a collusive beneficiary or an unwilling victim, and why? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.
- B. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion.
- C. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.
- D. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.

Answer: A

Explanation: Coercive corruption is the controlling principle. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A driving-test examiner demands cash merely to conduct the statutory test. Which corruption category best captures the relationship? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.
- B. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.
- C. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.
- D. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction.

Answer: B

Explanation: Coercive corruption is the controlling principle. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A contractor and an engineer agree to certify substandard rural road work so that both profit while villagers bear the damage. Which form of corruption is this? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

A. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.

B. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.

C. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction.

D. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion.

Answer: C

Explanation: Collusive corruption is the controlling principle. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A restaurant owner pays an inspector to ignore adulteration. Why does calling the owner merely a helpless victim misdescribe the ethical structure? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

A. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.

B. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion.

C. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.

D. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction.

Answer: D

Explanation: Collusive corruption is the controlling principle. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

An applicant can obtain a certificate only from one opaque counter, whose clerk fixes informal priorities. Which structural combination creates the strongest rent-seeking risk? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.
- B. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.
- C. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.
- D. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.

Answer: A

Explanation: Competition and discretion is the controlling principle. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A state shifts routine licence renewal to a time-stamped portal with published criteria. Why is this a preventive ethics reform rather than simply a technology upgrade? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.
- B. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.
- C. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.
- D. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction.

Answer: B

Explanation: Competition and discretion is the controlling principle. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

MGNREGA workers publicly verify muster rolls and works before payment. Which corrective principle is operating beyond ordinary internal inspection? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction.
- B. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.
- C. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion.
- D. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.

Answer: C

Explanation: Citizen empowerment is the controlling principle. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A hospital displays only a slogan about service but no timelines, grievance route, or information on entitlements. Why is this not an effective citizen charter? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.
- B. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.
- C. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.
- D. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion.

Answer: D

Explanation: Citizen empowerment is the controlling principle. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

A department digitises approvals but declines to investigate officials who manipulated legacy records. Which half of the anti-corruption response is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.
- B. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.
- C. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.
- D. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction.

Answer: A

Explanation: Prevention and punishment is the controlling principle. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A department prosecutes bribe-takers but preserves an opaque, delay-prone licensing system. Why might misconduct recur despite strong punishment? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.
- B. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.
- C. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly gain at the cost of society, as in false certification, tax evasion, adulteration, or manipulated procurement; unlike coercive corruption, both parties have an incentive to conceal the transaction.
- D. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.

Answer: B

Explanation: Prevention and punishment is the controlling principle. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A local majority demands that a district officer deny a lawful benefit to an unpopular minority. Which idea requires the officer to follow equal constitutional standards rather than social pressure? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where monopoly and unreviewable discretion dominate, corruption risk rises; competition, choice, transparent processes, and automation can reduce opportunity for rent-seeking, though they do not eliminate the need for accountability and ethical judgment.
- B. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion.
- C. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.
- D. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.

Answer: C

Explanation: Constitutional morality is the controlling principle. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

An officer says personal sympathy permits ignoring a hearing requirement. Why does constitutional morality connect good ends to lawful, accountable means? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Citizen empowerment through information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder participation, public consultation, and social audit turns a passive recipient into a check on power; it is a structural response to unequal access and discretion.
- B. Ethically sound governance requires both preventive redesign and credible enforcement: transparency and reduced discretion lower opportunities for wrongdoing, while rule-of-law enforcement and deterrent punishment address violations that prevention does not avert.
- C. Coercive corruption occurs when an official extracts payment or favour for a service to which a citizen is entitled, making the citizen an unwilling victim; its ethical core is extortion through public power, not a mutually beneficial bargain.
- D. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power.

Answer: D

Explanation: Constitutional morality is the controlling principle. Constitutional morality is cultivated through civil education and adherence to the rule of law; for a public servant it requires fidelity to constitutional values, reasoned restraint of personal prejudice, fair procedure, and accountable exercise of public power. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A defence purchase favours the most suitable equipment through transparent evaluation instead of commissions. Which national-power pathway is strengthened, beyond an individual officer's honesty? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.
- B. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.
- C. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.
- D. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.

Answer: A

Explanation: CNP and integrity is the controlling principle. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

A state claims that military spending alone establishes CNP while communal distrust undermines institutions. Which missing ethics-and-values dimension should an answer identify? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.
- B. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.
- C. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.
- D. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.

Answer: B

Explanation: CNP and integrity is the controlling principle. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

A district administration applies relief criteria equally across caste and religion during a flood. How can this ethical conduct strengthen national capacity beyond immediate welfare delivery? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.
- B. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.
- C. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.
- D. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.

Answer: C

Explanation: CNP and social harmony is the controlling principle. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A policy has impressive infrastructure targets but repeatedly treats vulnerable groups with contempt. Which CNP-related cost is likely to be overlooked? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.
- B. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.
- C. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.
- D. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.

Answer: D

Explanation: CNP and social harmony is the controlling principle. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A training programme teaches a revenue officer only forms and service rules, but not empathy, conflict handling, or accountability. Which competency gap is most relevant to the human interface? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.
- B. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.
- C. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.
- D. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.

Answer: A

Explanation: Mission Karmayogi is the controlling principle. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A department assigns a role solely by seniority despite a demonstrated mismatch in citizen-facing skills. How does a roles-based approach diagnose the problem? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.
- B. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.
- C. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.
- D. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.

Answer: B

Explanation: Mission Karmayogi is the controlling principle. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

An answer says 'corruption is bad' and lists RTI, punishment, and values without explaining how they alter discretion or accountability. Which answer-writing defect most weakens it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.
- B. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.
- C. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.
- D. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.

Answer: C

Explanation: Answer architecture is the controlling principle. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A candidate praises decentralisation but notes the risk of local elite capture and adds audit safeguards. Why is this stronger than a one-sided conclusion? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Social harmony is a direct ethics-and-values contribution to Comprehensive National Power because equal respect, constitutional conduct, and trusted institutions reduce internal fragmentation and make economic, strategic, and diplomatic capacities more durable.
- B. Mission Karmayogi frames capacity building around citizen-government interface and functional and behavioural competencies, shifting from a rules-based to a roles-based approach; ethical capacity therefore includes how public servants perform roles, not merely their knowledge of procedures.
- C. Ethics and values enhance Comprehensive National Power by improving institutional trust, economic predictability, procurement integrity, social harmony, scientific credibility, and diplomatic reliability; they are capability multipliers rather than a substitute for material economic or strategic capacity.
- D. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict.

Answer: D

Explanation: Answer architecture is the controlling principle. A high-quality ethics answer should state a precise thesis, explain the mechanism through relevant dimensions, use a concrete Indian administrative illustration, acknowledge a real limitation or counterpoint, and end with a qualified reasoned verdict. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: "Ethics encompasses several key dimensions that are crucial in guiding individuals and organizations towards morally responsible behaviour." Explain the key dimensions of ethics that influence human actions. Discuss how these dimensions shape ethical decision&making in the professional context.

Source / ownership: Exact English wording from locally held official PDF: books/mains/05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, Q1(b). The printed source uses 'decision&making'.

Model solution

Ethics supplies standards by which action is judged, not merely intentions by which an actor describes herself. Its important dimensions include duty and rights, consequences and harm, justice and fairness, virtues such as integrity and courage, care for affected persons, and accountability to the public. Together they make professional judgment reasoned rather than instinctive.

In a professional setting, duty prevents an officer from treating a citizen as a means; consequence asks who may be harmed; fairness checks unequal treatment; virtue tests character under pressure; and accountability requires reasons capable of public scrutiny. For example, while finalising a beneficiary list, a district officer should apply published eligibility criteria, hear errors, protect personal data, and record reasons for inclusion or exclusion. Compassion may prompt assistance, but cannot justify secretly bypassing the list for a favoured applicant.

No single dimension mechanically resolves every dilemma: rigid rule-following may ignore an exceptional hardship, while outcome-only reasoning can rationalise unfair means. Hence a public professional should balance legitimate consequences with constitutional duty, fair procedure, empathy, and review. The sound verdict is a decision that is both substantively humane and publicly defensible.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: "Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law." Examine the significance of constitutional morality for public servant highlighting the role in promoting good governance and ensuring accountability in public administration.

Source / ownership: Exact English wording from locally held official PDF: books/mains/UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, Q1(b). The printed source uses 'adherence'.

Model solution

Constitutional morality is disciplined fidelity to constitutional values and lawful procedure, rather than obedience to personal preference, social majority, or official convenience. Because it is learned through civic education and rule-of-law practice, it asks a public servant to convert equality, dignity, liberty, fairness, and accountability into everyday administrative conduct.

It promotes good governance in three ways. First, it restrains arbitrary power: reasons, hearings, and published criteria prevent discretionary favour. Second, it protects minorities and vulnerable persons when local prejudice is politically popular. Third, it makes decisions auditable because the officer can state the constitutional value and rule supporting the action. A district magistrate allocating flood relief, for instance, must apply transparent need-based criteria across caste, religion, and political affiliation, record exclusions, and provide grievance review. This is not charity; it is equal public duty.

Constitutional morality does not require mechanical rule worship. Exceptional circumstances may demand humane discretion, but discretion must remain reasoned, non-discriminatory, and reviewable. Thus it is the ethical bridge between legal authority and legitimate administration: it makes power citizen-centred while keeping it accountable.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss the role of ethics and values in enhancing the three major components of Comprehensive National Power and social harmony.

Source / ownership: Older routed demand, neutral rendering from the Ethics Topic 01 PYQ integration; not claimed as verbatim wording in this data file.

Model solution

Comprehensive National Power (CNP) is not reducible to military assets. It rests on material capability, institutional capacity, social cohesion, technological credibility, and external trust. Ethics and values strengthen these components by making power reliable, legitimate, and sustainable.

Economically, predictable rules, integrity, and low graft reduce uncertainty for citizens and investors. Strategically, ethical procurement and apolitical professional conduct help ensure that public money purchases capability rather than private commissions. Socially, equal respect, tolerance, and constitutional conduct reduce fragmentation and enable collective action. Technologically, research integrity and responsible data use sustain confidence in innovation. Diplomatically, a state that honours commitments and acts consistently accumulates credibility. India's post-liberalisation experience, noted by the 2nd ARC, illustrates the economic channel: reduced discretion and greater transparency can curb corruption in competitive sectors.

Values alone cannot compensate for weak industry, defence preparedness, or state capacity; nor does social harmony arise from slogans. They need institutional expression through fair laws, transparent administration, and accountable leadership. Therefore ethics is not a decorative soft-power claim: it is a multiplier that enables economic, strategic, and social components of CNP to reinforce rather than undermine one another.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Examine education as a pervasive tool for individual development and social transformation, with reference to NEP 2020.

Source / ownership: Older routed demand, neutral rendering from the Ethics Topic 01 PYQ integration; not claimed as verbatim wording in this data file.

Model solution

Education is pervasive because it develops capability and also shapes the moral habits through which persons use capability. It can cultivate reasoning, empathy, scientific temper, constitutional values, and respect for diversity; hence its effects extend from individual agency to social institutions.

For the individual, education enlarges informed choice, employability, self-respect, and the ability to question prejudice. For society, it can weaken inherited exclusion, support gender equality, foster civic participation, and create a workforce able to respond to changing public needs. In an Indian administrative illustration, a school that ensures girls' attendance, inclusive classroom practice, and grievance support does more than improve examination outcomes: it changes who can later participate in public and economic life. The ethical mechanism is civil education: repeated experience of equal treatment makes constitutional morality more practicable.

Yet schooling is not automatically transformative. Poor quality, digital exclusion, segregated access, or rote moral instruction can reproduce hierarchy rather than challenge it. Education must therefore be accompanied by accessible institutions, fair opportunities, and accountable implementation. On balance, it is a powerful long-term instrument of transformation precisely when knowledge, values, and equal access are joined.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss ethics in human actions and its role in resolving conflicts in everyday functioning.

Source / ownership: Older routed demand, neutral rendering from the Ethics Topic 01 PYQ integration; not claimed as verbatim wording in this data file.

Model solution

Ethics in human action means selecting and justifying conduct through standards such as honesty, fairness, non-harm, empathy, duty, and accountability. It matters in everyday conflicts because disputes usually involve not only competing interests but also unequal power, incomplete information, and questions of respect.

Ethical reasoning resolves conflict by first identifying stakeholders and facts, then separating entitlement from preference, hearing affected persons, testing foreseeable harm, and giving reasons that can be publicly defended. Consider a municipal officer facing competing claims over water-tanker supply in a drought. A first-come rule may appear neutral, but it can disadvantage settlements with poor transport or information. A fair response publishes need-based criteria, reserves an emergency channel for vulnerable households, records allocation, and provides a grievance route. This combines justice with compassion rather than choosing one against the other.

Ethics cannot remove every scarcity conflict, and consensus may be impossible. An officer must still take a timely decision under law. Its value is that it converts power from personal preference into a transparent, reviewable process. Thus ethical action does not promise universal satisfaction; it produces a more legitimate and humane settlement.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Explain how a positive and a negative mindset can lead to different interpretations of rules and regulations.

Source / ownership: Older routed demand, neutral rendering from the Ethics Topic 01 PYQ integration; not claimed as verbatim wording in this data file.

Model solution

A mindset shapes how an official sees the purpose of a rule. A positive mindset treats regulation as an instrument to secure fairness, safety, and public trust; a negative mindset treats it chiefly as an obstacle, a source of power, or a shield against responsibility. The difference is ethical when interpretation affects citizens' rights and access.

A constructive officer reads a rule with its public purpose, applies it consistently, and explains any refusal. A cynical officer may exploit ambiguity to delay service, demand informal payment, or deny reasonable assistance by saying 'the file cannot move.' For example, during disability-certificate verification, a facilitative officer helps an applicant correct a curable document error and records the reasoned decision; a negative one mechanically rejects the claim despite available verification and no risk to legality. The former respects both rule and citizen dignity.

Positive interpretation is not permission to ignore mandatory conditions or grant favouritism. Compassion must operate within law, published criteria, and equal treatment. The sound administrative stance is therefore purposive but accountable: it avoids both obstructive literalism and arbitrary benevolence, and keeps the citizen-government interface lawful, responsive, and reviewable.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish ethics from morality. Why does the distinction matter to a public servant? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Ethics is the systematic, reasoned examination of standards of right conduct; morality is the set of beliefs and practices actually held by an individual or community. In ordinary speech the terms overlap, but the distinction matters because a popular practice need not be ethically justified.

For a public servant, morality may explain why colleagues regard a festival gift, political recommendation, or preferential treatment as normal. Ethics asks a further question: is the conduct fair, compatible with public duty, non-harmful, and capable of being publicly defended? A revenue officer cannot justify giving a relative's mutation file priority merely because family loyalty is socially valued. Public office requires impartiality, reasons, and equal access.

The distinction must not produce contempt for community values. Local knowledge can reveal genuine hardship and guide humane service delivery. But where custom conflicts with constitutional equality or public trust, the officer must use ethical reasoning and lawful procedure. Thus the public servant should respect moral diversity while testing conduct against principled, citizen-facing standards.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Why is conduct that is legal not necessarily proper in public office? Illustrate. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Legality means conformity with enacted law; propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate to the responsibilities and appearance of public office. The gap matters because rules cannot enumerate every conflict, and public trust can be damaged before a legal violation is proved.

For example, a district procurement officer may legally attend a private dinner hosted by a bidder if no payment or formal favour is established. Yet the event can create a reasonable apprehension of bias and compromise the officer's independence. The prudent response is disclosure, recusal where necessary, and avoidance of hospitality that a citizen could fairly see as influencing a decision. Similar reasoning applies to informal meetings, use of official information, and public praise for connected firms.

Propriety should not become vague moral policing or a device to punish harmless personal conduct. It requires a nexus with office, public perception, and entrusted power. Accordingly, legal compliance is the floor, not the ceiling: ethical administration also protects impartiality and the visible integrity of decision-making.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the claim that corruption is structurally produced rather than merely a failure of character. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Corruption is partly a failure of character, but it is often structurally enabled. The 2nd ARC connects risk to public authority, discretion, control of funds, asymmetric power, historical habits of unchallenged authority, over-regulation, and excessive centralisation. These conditions shape temptations and the citizen's capacity to resist.

A character-only explanation recommends moral education. It is necessary because integrity, empathy, and courage influence conduct under pressure. Yet it cannot explain why corruption falls when opaque intermediaries are removed without a change in personal virtue. The ARC's observation that competition and transparency reduced corruption in sectors after liberalisation supports institutional reasoning. In land administration, time-stamped digital records, published fees, and appeal routes can reduce a clerk's scope to demand speed money from a vulnerable applicant.

Structural reform also has limits. Automation can exclude digitally weak citizens, decentralisation can create local monopolies, and corruption can migrate to discretionary areas if political incentives remain distorted. Hence the false choice must be rejected. The defensible remedy combines values-based leadership, transparent design, citizen empowerment, independent audit, and deterrent enforcement. Character makes integrity possible; institutions make it durable and verifiable. Recruitment, supervision, and public review must reinforce the same incentive for ethical conduct.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Distinguish coercive from collusive corruption and draw out the implications for ethical response. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Coercive corruption occurs when a public functionary extracts payment for a service to which the citizen is entitled; the citizen is an unwilling victim. Collusive corruption occurs when giver and taker jointly secure private gain while society bears the loss. The distinction changes both diagnosis and remedy.

A clerk demanding money to release a sanctioned pension exemplifies coercion: the widow seeks no improper advantage and is constrained by need and delay. In contrast, an engineer and contractor jointly certifying substandard road work exemplify collusion: both gain, while taxpayers and villagers lose quality and safety. Coercion requires safe complaint channels, time-bound service guarantees, fee transparency, and protection for the victim. Collusion requires procurement transparency, technical audit, asset and beneficial-interest scrutiny, whistle-blower protection, and investigation of both sides of the bargain.

In practice, categories can blur: a business may initially face coercion yet later seek an illegal advantage. Therefore labels must follow facts, not stereotypes about bribe-givers. The ethical verdict is that reform must reduce discretionary extraction while also disrupting mutually beneficial networks that damage the public interest. Training should make officers recognise the distinction before they choose a complaint, audit, investigation, or victim-support response.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Citizen empowerment is not a welfare add-on but an ethical redesign of the human interface. Discuss. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Citizen empowerment is an ethical redesign because it changes the relationship between the holder of public power and the person dependent on it. At the human interface, officials may control information, time, certification, and access. Where a poor or unorganised citizen cannot question those controls, formal entitlement can become dependence and discretion can become extraction.

The 2nd ARC identifies Right to Information, effective citizens' charters, stakeholder involvement, public consultation, and social auditing as correctives. RTI reduces informational monopoly; a meaningful charter states service, fee, timeline, officer, and grievance route; consultation gives affected persons voice before a decision; and social audit lets beneficiaries test official records against lived reality. In an Indian rural works programme, public verification of muster rolls and completed assets can expose false entries that a closed departmental file may conceal. Such tools promote dignity, accountability, and substantive equality, not merely administrative efficiency.

Empowerment has conditions. A portal without assisted access can deepen exclusion; social audit can be captured by local elites; information without response can create frustration. It must therefore be paired with literacy support, accessible formats, independent grievance handling, protection against retaliation, and enforceable follow-up. Punishment for proved misconduct remains necessary.

Thus citizen empowerment does not replace honest officials or rule enforcement. It makes integrity less dependent on individual goodwill by giving citizens information, voice, and remedy. Its ethical achievement is to convert the citizen from supplicant to rights-bearing participant in accountable governance. It thereby improves both the fairness of outcomes and the legitimacy of the procedure that produces them in ordinary encounters with the state.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: How can constitutional morality and role-based civil-service capacity together improve the ethical quality of public administration? Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Constitutional morality supplies the normative compass of public administration; role-based capacity supplies the ability to practise it at the citizen-government interface. The first requires fidelity to equality, dignity, liberty, fair procedure, and accountable power even when prejudice or convenience points elsewhere. The second recognises that ethical administration depends on functional and behavioural competence, not rules memorised in isolation.

A constitutional public servant gives reasons, avoids discrimination, hears affected persons, and keeps discretion reviewable. Mission Karmayogi's National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building is relevant because the DoPT describes its focus on the citizen-government interface, functional and behavioural competencies, and a rules-based to roles-based shift. A welfare officer handling disability benefits, for example, needs procedural knowledge, data discipline, empathy, communication, and the courage to resist a politically favoured but ineligible claim. Capacity without constitutional morality can become efficient exclusion; morality without capability can remain an aspiration unable to deliver timely justice.

Training alone cannot cure opaque systems, perverse incentives, or political pressure. It must be supported by transparent criteria, audit trails, grievance redress, leadership example, and proportionate enforcement. Nor should roles-based management be misread as discretion to ignore service safeguards.

The reasoned conclusion is that constitutional morality determines the public purpose of administrative power, while role-based capacity operationalises it. Their union produces not merely compliant officials but competent, humane, and accountable public institutions. Performance assessment should therefore examine citizen-facing conduct and reasoned outcomes, not only course completion or mechanical target achievement. Feedback, grievance data, and reasoned review should inform improvement without turning complex ethical service into a crude numerical score alone.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.